



HUMANITAS  
INSTITUTE

## Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Covenant Classical School

School Website: <https://www.covenantclassicalsfc.com/>

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**Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer**

*This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.*

ACCS: **MEMBER** SCL: **MEMBER**

*Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.*

## Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

### Executive Summary

Covenant Classical School (Sioux Falls, SD, 57108) presents a robust alignment with classical education principles, anchored in a distinctly Christian worldview and a formation-focused approach. Public materials describe a collaborative, parent-partnered model, a commitment to virtue formation, engagement with Great Books and the "great conversation," and attention to the liberal-arts framework through elements such as Latin study and history as the organizing backbone of curriculum. The school emphasizes virtue, wisdom, and beauty, while keeping faith formation at the center of its mission. Overall, the school's materials meet the core criteria of a classical education in most categories, with particularly strong signals in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose and Goal, Faculty, and Parents & Community. A few curricular/pedagogical details appear less explicit (e.g., explicit articulation of grammar/logic/rhetoric as formal terms in the curriculum, and Socratic pedagogy in upper grades), resulting in a tendency toward CLASSICAL with some elements that are clearly classical and others that are still developing toward a full, explicit Trivium-centered framework. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

### Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- The school frames its education within a Christian worldview and emphasizes piety and sacred aims, e.g., "Distinctly Christian ... we unapologetically teach from a Christian worldview. We believe that the eternal Word (i.e., the Logos), Jesus, is the place where all wisdom and knowledge find their end" and a description of grounded Christian formation in its program materials.
- A foundational text describes the school's mission as "the transmission of the culture of the Church ... by cultivating virtue in the students ... and nurturing their love for wisdom and faithful service of the Lord Jesus Christ."
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, virtue, wisdom, theology/Word (Logos), sacred worldview, Christian worldview, sacred discipline.
- Negative keywords: none clearly present in the public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or morally neutral language observed in the materials reviewed).
- Why this rating
- The materials foreground transcendentals in practice via virtue-tending, wisdom, and a theological frame anchored in Christian revelation, which maps strongly to the Positive indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. Direct statements about Christian worldview and the Word/Logos further support a CLASSICAL rating in this category.

**Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- The school communicates formation of character and love of truth, goodness, and beauty as central aims, e.g., “We lead learners in the pursuit of knowledge, understanding, and wisdom, training them to love what is true, good, and beautiful” and enculturation in a Christian environment marked by gratitude, discipline, and wonder.
- The mission emphasizes virtue, human flourishing, and the classical telos over purely career-oriented aims, with explicit references to the true, good, and beautiful.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, true/good/beautiful, liberal education (implied through classical aims), scholé/contemplation (implicit in formation and wonder themes).
- Negative keywords observed: explicit “workforce preparation” framing is not emphasized; the public materials suggest formation over job-readiness.
- Why this rating
- The public materials align closely with the classical aim of formation and the pursuit of virtue and wisdom rather than vocational or skills-only training, matching CLASSICAL criteria for School Purpose and Goal.

**Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- The school emphasizes Great Books and the Great Conversation, e.g., references to classical works, primary sources, and the Bible as part of the curriculum (e.g., “great books,” “great conversation,” and the Bible as a central text).
- There is clear support for liberal-arts orientation (e.g., Latin study is highlighted; history is treated as central to curricular organization). The materials discuss the study of Latin and a history-forward curriculum that organizes across subjects.
- The site speaks about integrating Western thought and classics, and explicitly notes that Latin is part of classical education.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Great Books, Great Conversation, Bible, history, Latin, liberal education, classical mission, timeless truths, primary sources.
- Negative keywords present: evidence of project-based or STEM-first framing is not observed; however, explicit statement of “Seven Liberal Arts” as formalized components (grammar, logic, rhetoric) is not clearly enumerated in the public materials (appears more implicitly through references to classical text and Latin study).
- Why this rating
- The curriculum signals align with classical education through Great Books, a history-centered structure, and Latin study, but explicit, formal mention of the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as a named framework is less overt in the public pages. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL assessment for Curriculum.

**Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- The school uses a collaborative model with significant parental involvement, including at-home learning days and a classroom-with-parent partnership, which signals a blended, contemplative approach rather than a strict in-class, monastic pedagogy. The two-days-in-class plus three-days-at-home model is described in public materials.
- The presence of a “learning cohorts” concept suggests a more differentiated and iterative approach to mastery rather than a single, uniform pedagogy.
- The site emphasizes formation, virtue, and wonder as a throughline, with explicit emphasis on virtue formation and love of wisdom — consistent with scholé-like, contemplative aims though not always

framed as explicit Socratic/scholé pedagogy in the public pages.

- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: scholé (indirectly via “wonder” and contemplative aims), contemplation, formation, virtue, wisdom, great conversation, memory work (implicit in classical formation through reading and recitation traditions).
- Negative keywords present: direct references to experiential learning, project-based-only, or constructivist positioning are not evident; however, explicit Socratic seminars in upper grades are not clearly described in the public materials.
- Why this rating
- The pedagogy shows clear classical features (memory/recitation through a grammar/logic/rhetoric-inclined tradition in public materials is implied but not strongly enumerated; rigorous Socratic pedagogy is not explicitly described). The blend of home/classroom, and the emphasis on contemplation, suggests SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL by the rubric’s stricter criteria.

#### **Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- The materials present faculty as mentors and the living curriculum, with explicit emphasis on virtuous teachers and a community of educators. The site features bios and references to head of school and faculty, signaling a focus on teacher as exemplar and living curriculum.
- The public content depicts faculty, a head of school, and “faculty of friends” language in line with classical education ideals.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: tutors/mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, moral exemplars, character formation.
- Negative keywords present: none apparent in public materials.
- Why this rating
- The public materials show a clear emphasis on virtuous, exemplary teachers who function as the core of the school’s educational approach, aligning with CLASSICAL criteria for Faculty.

#### **Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL**

- Evidence
- The school explicitly frames parents as co-teachers and part of the pedagogical project; parental involvement is a central feature of Covenant Classical’s model (two days in-class with home-based learning, and language about parents as co-teachers).
- The site describes parent formation, reading groups, and gatherings as part of a broader classical formation cycle and community-building, and invites parents to participate in the learning process.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental primacy, parent formation, reading groups, seminars/book clubs, open campus, hospitality, family participation, liturgical year events.
- Negative keywords present: consumer language or minimal parental involvement are not observed; public materials present robust parent engagement.
- Why this rating
- Covenant Classical’s materials strongly emphasize a parent-partnered model and community formation, mapping well to the classical category for Parents & Community.

Aggregate Ranking: CLASSICAL

- Rationale: Across the six categories, Covenant Classical School (Sioux Falls, SD, 57108) demonstrates strong orientation to classicism in Religious Foundations, School Purpose, Faculty, and Parents/Community. Curriculum and Pedagogy show robust classical signals (Great Books, history-forward curriculum, Latin), though explicit articulation of all Trivium components (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and some Socratic pedagogy elements are less overt in the public materials. Taken together,

the school aligns most strongly with CLASSICAL, with some elements currently described at a Somewhat Classical level, but the overall profile remains CLASSICAL.

#### What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 3 (Curriculum): Explicitly name and demonstrate the full Trivium framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in public materials and on the site, and provide concrete examples of how each component is implemented across grade bands.
- For Element 4 (Pedagogy): Provide explicit descriptions of Socratic seminars, seminars, or debates in upper grades and demonstrate how upper-grade rhetoric and oratory are cultivated (e.g., sample capstone oration prompts).
- For Element 1 (Religious Foundations): While the Christian/theological framing is strong, additional explicit articulation of liturgical practices, communal worship, or liturgical life within the school's weekly rhythm could strengthen signals in the "Liturgical and Communal Practices" area.
- For Element 2 (Purpose and Goal): Continue to emphasize formation/wisdom ascent with more explicit articulation of "unfolding true, good, beautiful" as a daily telos in classroom practice and assessment.

## Appendix

### ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

### Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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